

Chris J Shanku

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Summary

I spent 8 years at Microsoft selling AI. Now I build it - for the life I almost lost.

Experience

Senior Director, US Financial Services Practice, iLink Digital (2025 - present)

Atlanta, GA

- Building a \$4M annual revenue pipeline through consultative pre-sales, Microsoft co-sell motions, and direct enterprise engagement across banking, insurance, and capital markets.
- Designed and deployed AI-powered operational tools for the practice: automated meeting prep, a voice-preserving email drafting agent with a review gate, and a follow-up engine that risk-scores every commitment.
- Built Intel Brief (FSI competitive intelligence) and The Ledger (relationship health across 100+ contacts).
- Leading iLink's presence at Microsoft FabCon: workshop proposals, partner engagement, and executive scheduling.

Senior Specialist, Data & AI (Banking), Microsoft (2022 - 2025)

Atlanta, GA

- Delivered 97% Azure Data Services revenue in FY25 (97% FY24, 89% FY23).
- Led Banking in the FY24 Azure Arc-enablement Hero Motion, enabling >\$1.4M in net-new ADS; drove a \$1M Databricks win at a Midwest bank.
- Facilitated the Ally GenAI case study - the first GenAI use case across all of US FSI - plus Xome Data Modernization, both on Microsoft's Customer Stories.
- Named to Microsoft's Executive Briefing Center (EBC) speaker list for AI and Fabric; keynoted the Microsoft + OpenAI partnership to a top-200 exec audience.
- Only FSI representative selected for the Atlanta Innovation Hub Ambassadors program, giving tours and demos as a proxy Innovation Hub Architect.

Awards: Hero Award (Dec 2022) · Making It Happen nomination (Jan 2024)

Senior Technical Specialist, Intelligence / Power Platform / Power BI (FSI), Microsoft (2017 - 2022)

Kansas City, MO

- The go-to Power BI expert across all of Financial Services; met or exceeded quota FY18-FY22 (96% VTT with 50% YoY growth in FY21).
- Hosted 40+ Power BI Dashboard-in-a-Day workshops; selected to speak at Power BI World Tour (Oct 2018).
- Delivered >1,000% VTT in FY20 as Power Platform Technical Specialist; led biweekly PBI SWAT sessions across Modern Work, Data & AI, and Biz Apps.

Awards: Peer Nominated Award (Sep 2019)

Manager, Digital Insights, Valorem Consulting (now Valorem Reply) (2016 - 2017)

Kansas City, MO

- Led the Modern Data Experience team (12 consultants, \$3M+ annual revenue) across business strategy, P&L, and all technical pre-sales; grew the practice by over 500%.
- Created ConsulTrain, an internal readiness program that upskilled consultants on customer engagement and consulting excellence.

- Hand-picked by Microsoft TSPs to deliver technical pre-sales on Power BI, Power Apps, Flow, Cortana Intelligence, and SQL 2016; sold \$1M+ to 15+ EPG and SMS&P clients.

BI Solutions Consultant, Valorem Consulting (2014 - 2016)

Kansas City, MO

- Lead Data & Analytics consultant for self-service BI delivery and technical pre-sales; sold and delivered \$150K+ of D&A revenue.
- Built Tabular SSAS cubes and Power BI dashboards with complex DAX; established company-wide credibility as the go-to BI reference.

BI Architect / Offshore Manager / Delivery Lead, Avanade (2009 - 2014)

Atlanta, GA

- Wore many hats at the intersection of Accenture's consulting discipline and Microsoft's technical innovation, delivering scalable BI on the SQL Server 2012 stack across complex stakeholder environments.
- Led offshore delivery teams (2-5 resources); resolved 500+ defects across 5-10 lines of business; trained dozens of new consultants through 30+-participant classroom seminars.
- Where I first learned to say "yes" to opportunity, even when it came disguised as uncertainty.

Education

University of Georgia - Bachelor of Science, Mathematics (Athens, GA)

Certifications

Microsoft: Azure AI Fundamentals, Azure Data Fundamentals, Power Platform Fundamentals, Microsoft 365 Fundamentals, Power BI Data Analyst, MCSE Data Management & Analytics, MCSA BI Reporting, Microsoft Certified Trainer

Kimball Group: Dimensional Modeling in Depth

Dale Carnegie: Present to Persuade, Powerful Conversations, Disagree Agreeably

Skills

Cloud Platforms: Microsoft Azure, Microsoft 365, Google Workspace

AI / ML: Azure OpenAI, Anthropic Claude, Google Gemini, LangChain, pgvector, RAG architectures, AI agent frameworks

Data & Analytics: Microsoft Fabric, Power BI (9 yrs), SQL Server, CouchDB, PostgreSQL, Databricks, DAX

Development: Python, JavaScript / TypeScript, React, FastAPI, .NET / C#, PowerShell

Automation: n8n, Power Automate, Power Platform, Docker, GitHub Actions

Pre-Sales: Solution architecture, Proposal development, Technical discovery, RFP response, Executive briefings, Partner enablement

AI Portfolio

The Grove (Personal LifeOS · Multi-agent)

The Grove is the personal life operating system I built for my family and me - a multi-agent harness that captures what matters across work, recovery, co-parenting, and health, then pushes the right nudge at the right moment. It runs on a homelab I own end to end, and it treats my own life like a product I ship to every day.

thegrove.pro

Human in the Loop (Media · LinkedIn Live · Every Friday)

Human in the Loop is a weekly LinkedIn Live show about building with AI - made with AI at every step, from research to the on-air graphics. Each episode works a real problem in the open instead of pitching a finished answer, so the audience sees the messy middle where a human still has to make the call.

15 episodes. humanintheloop.stream

iLink Tools (AI tools for an FSI sales team)

iLink Tools is the internal suite I built with agents so an FSI sales team sells smarter - meeting prep, competitive intel, account research, and regulated-workflow patterns, all wired to the signals a seller actually acts on. Sixteen tools have shipped so far, each one earning its place by removing a real piece of manual work from the week.

16 tools built. ilink.tools

SignalScope graduated into WayFact.

twelfth.help (Recovery · Daily delivery)

twelfth.help carries a daily recovery message to the person who needs it, the way the twelfth step asks us to carry it to the next one still struggling. It is a productized sibling of the step work I do every morning - free and open for anyone in recovery, with a managed track for the fellowships and programs that want it run for them.

twelfth.help

WayFact (FSI data curation)

WayFact is an FSI data-curation engine that turns raw market signal into verified, decision-ready fact - the productized graduation of the SignalScope work I built inside iLink Tools. It runs as a standalone venture under TheGrove AI LLC, focused on the one thing regulated financial-services teams cannot outsource to a hallucinating model: knowing what is actually true.

Status: private beta.

Storytelling & Speaking

Award-winning storyteller and regular performer at The Moth. Stories draw on fatherhood, recovery, career pivots, and the courage to say yes before you know how.

The Moth: StorySLAM - Winner (It's Time, Dec 2024); StorySLAM - 2nd Place (The Divorce, Feb 2025); GrandSLAM - 9.0/10 (I Knew You'd Come Back, Jun 2025).

Speaking: 12 engagements, 595+ reached, 2018-2026 span, 8 uga semesters.

Updated 2026-07-16 · <https://shanku.net/resume/>